

Avoiding bugs

Pregnancy reduces the efficiency of your immune system, increasing your risk of an infection. When you're traveling, "stomach bugs" caused by contaminated food and water are more likely to strike.

If you're unsure about local tap water, buy bottled water (make sure the seal is unbroken) and use it when brushing your teeth as well as for drinking. Avoid drinks with ice and don't eat salads or fruit you can't peel since they may have been washed in contaminated water. A less obvious danger is fruit such as melon, which may have been injected with water to increase its weight.

Avoid outdoor stalls or cafés where food might have been prepared hours in advance. Try to find restaurants where food is freshly cooked and standards seem high. Be scrupulous about hygiene, and carry moist wipes in case hand-washing facilities are inadequate.

On the trip

If you're traveling by car, stop regularly to stretch your legs, have a snack, or find a bathroom. On a train or plane, keep your circulation moving with foot and ankle exercises, and every so often walk down the aisle. Stay hydrated by drinking lots of water or juice. Carry a bag of dried fruit or nuts with you on trips. Comforts, such as a cushion and a cooling water spritzer, can make a trip more bearable.

Vacation activities

Forego water skiing and horseback riding, as a fall could harm your baby. Scuba diving is dangerous because of the risk of air bubbles forming in the bloodstream and the potential lack of oxygen. Avoid going on white-knuckle theme park rides.

If you're used to exercising, there is no reason not to go swimming or walking, just don't overdo it—hiking up hills under a blazing sun could send your temperature soaring. In the first trimester especially, extreme heat can affect fetal development. You might also become dehydrated, which, later on, can increase the risk of premature labor.

Hot tubs and saunas should be avoided since the heat could make you feel faint and may be harmful to your baby. Some aromatherapy oils may be toxic to the baby, especially in the early months. Look for spas with treatments for pregnant moms and always seek a qualified pre- and postpartum therapist, if possible.

In pregnancy, your skin becomes more sensitive to the sun so be careful to protect against overexposure.

ASK AN EXPERT

I am five months pregnant and about to go on a beach vacation. Is it safe for me to sunbathe while I'm pregnant?

It is safe to do a little sunbathing in pregnancy. However, it is important to avoid getting overheated since this will make you feel very unwell. It is generally best to sit in the shade and make sure you have plenty of cool drinks to avoid becoming dehydrated. Remember to use a strong sunscreen because your skin may be more sensitive than usual while you are pregnant.

I'm worried about flying to my vacation destination because someone told me there is a high risk of DVT in pregnancy. Is this true?

[Deep vein thrombosis \(DVT\)](#), the formation of a blood clot in a vein (often in a leg), is sometimes caused by long periods of immobility, such as sitting on a plane. Although the risk factor may be slightly increased in pregnant women, because their blood tends to clot more easily, the chance